the expanding urban sprawl. Scattered across modern Indian cities, there remain enclaves where the contours of the old villages can be clearly discerned decades after the surrounding farmlands were converted into offices, roads, houses and shops.

In some ways, this is in keeping with Indian civilization—the ability to allow the past to live on in the present. Tucked away behind modern buildings, the former villages make their presence felt in many different ways—as the source of vagrant cattle, as homes to armies of informal workers, as the place to visit if one wants to buy bathroom tiles or electricals. Many of these villages have been newly absorbed into the urban fabric, but some are very old and have been embedded in the city for generations. In Mumbai, the villages of Bandra and Walkeshwar retain strong vestiges of their origins despite being located at the heart of a throbbing megapolis.

For the purposes of this book, I will limit myself to the experience of urban villages in and around Delhi. My studies suggest that, roughly speaking, these villages go through the following cycle. In the first stage, the farmers sell their farmland to the government or to a developer but the village settlement itself is usually left alone. This settlement, dubbed as ‘lal dora’, is exempt from the usual municipal and building codes. The former farmers now notice that there is inadequate housing for the legions of workers, contractors and suppliers who have descended on the construction site. They, therefore, use their newly acquired capital and the exemption to build a mish-mash of buildings within the lal-dora area. Often built with little regard for safety or ventilation, these become home to construction workers and suppliers. Thus, the village turns into a slum with the former villagers as slumlords.

A few years pass and construction work in that particular area begins to wind down. The construction workers drift away to other sites. New migrants move in—security guards, maids, drivers and other people who work in the newly built urban space. The shops selling construction material and hardware are steadily replaced by shops selling mobile phones, street-food, car-parts and so on. For the first time we see private and,